

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1991-05-01

1 dear friends,
2 instructed us to send you the following reply. . . .
3 first of all, we are asked to explain that although bahá'ís believe that the
4 Teachings and order of bahá'u'lláh are the solution to the current problems
5 of mankind, they abstain completely from ever attempting to put them into effect
through political action. only if people voluntarily accept them and
6 submit themselves freely to this order will it be implemented in the world.
7 bahá'ís should never attempt to impose their belief on anyone. bahá'u'lláh
8 has given certain teachings which bahá'ís believe to be true; they offer these
9 teachings to the rest of mankind. whosoever accepts them is a bahá'í, but
10 everyone is free to reject them. No one is ever compelled to become a bahá'í,
11 nor is anyone compelled to remain a bahá'í. if one has accepted the bahá'í
12 faith and later concludes that one has made a mistake, one is free to with-
13 draw, and no stigma is attached to such an action. in all such things bahá'ís
14 uphold bahá'u'lláh's principle of independent investigation of truth.

but one must ask what is the truth? Naturally human beings are con-

15 tinually discovering more and more about the truth. god is infinite, so his 108.13

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110 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

111 20truth also is infinite. Nevertheless, as human knowledge progresses there are

112 certain truths that are clearly established. Acceptance of such truths is not

113 a surrender of freedom but is a free acceptance of things as they are. for

114 example it is now clearly established by science that the earth moves round

115 the sun, and not vice versa. Any human being is free to believe the contrary but to do
so is not an assertion of freedom, it is an evidence of ignorance or

116 foolishness. in the same way, to accept that bahá'u'lláh's claim to be a mani-
117 festation of god is true is not a surrender of freedom but the acceptance of
118 a conclusion that one has confirmed to one's own satisfaction.

119 bahá'u'lláh teaches, and bahá'ís believe, that the fundamental truths of
120 religion are not discovered by human beings but are revealed to mankind
121 by god through his manifestations. whether or not this belief is true is,
122 clearly, a matter of profound importance. if one does not accept it, one is

123 free to adopt all manner of viewpoints including the one propounded by you in your
letter, namely, that the followers of all the different religions should live together in harmony
without becoming one religion, and that one can choose certain of bahá'u'lláh's teachings
and reject others. This

124 is a valid position, but the point that you should realize is that it is not the bahá'í
position. bahá'ís respect your right to hold it, but you cannot

125 hold it and be a bahá'í because a bahá'í, by definition, accepts bahá'u'lláh
126 as the manifestation of god for this age and upholds his covenant as,
127 in the words of 'Abdu'l-b ahá, "the axis of the oneness of the world of

humanity."

128 109-1

129 bahá'ís believe that in this age god has revealed through bahá'u'lláh the
130 Teachings which will lead the followers of all religions to recognize their
131 common foundation so that they will flow into this latest dispensation of
132 god's revelation like rivers into one ocean and, in the words of jesus, "there
133 shall be one fold and one shepherd."109-2 They also believe that the law
134 of god revealed by bahá'u'lláh for this stage of human history, and the
135 institutions that he has founded, are the bedrock on which the unity and
136 harmony of mankind will be built. This is what they teach, because this is

137 what they believe to be the truth. Nevertheless, this does not prevent their living
together in harmony with those who believe otherwise, or stop their

138 collaborating in humanitarian activities with their fellow human beings of
139 all other religions and of none.

140 109-1. Tdp , no. 8.8.

141 109-2. j ohn 10:16 (kjv).109.4

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110 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

111 205it is apparent from your letters that you have not properly studied or

understood the bahá'í teachings and may well have been antagonized by

112 shortcomings among members of the bahá'í community. of course, bahá'ís

113 try not to have shortcomings. They are striving with varying success to put

114 the teachings of bahá'u'lláh into effect in their lives and to raise up the in-

115 stitutions which he has ordained. individuals and even Spiritual Assemblies

116 are imperfect—this is an inevitable aspect of growth—but they have the satisfaction of witnessing improvement and maturation as the years go by.

The house of justice hopes that you will make a deeper study of the

117 bahá'í teachings in collaboration with your bahá'í friends and, even if you

118 finally decide that you cannot accept them, that you will be able to collabo-rate with b
ahá'ís and all others in the building of a better world.

119 with all good wishes,

Department of tHe secretariat

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Message to the Pacific Women's Conference

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]